

# ENGLISH FROM ZERO TO MASTER LEVEL

VOLUME 1, PART A (REBUILT — FULL TEXTBOOK DEPTH)

Foundations of the Sentence & The Complete Noun System

TEXTBOOK • WORKBOOK • REFERENCE • EXAM PREP

This is Part A of the rebuilt Volume 1 — Foundations and a complete, exhaustive treatment of Nouns.  
Part B (Verbs, Tenses, and beyond) continues the course at the same depth.

# HOW TO USE THIS VOLUME

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This book is built to be read slowly, worked through, and returned to — not skimmed once. Every major topic follows the same cycle:

**TEACH → DEMONSTRATE → CONTRAST → APPLY → PRACTICE → TEST → CORRECT → REINFORCE**

- **Read the explanation once for understanding, not memorisation.** The examples are where real learning happens.
- **Do every practice set on paper before checking answers.** Seeing an answer before attempting it teaches recognition, not production — and production is what you'll need in real writing and in exams.
- **Pay special attention to the "Common Confusion" and "Exam Trap" boxes.** These target exactly the places where CDS/AFCAT-style questions are designed to catch you.
- **Don't skip the "easy" sections.** Several of the most-missed competitive exam questions are on topics test-takers assumed they already knew.
- **Every example count in this book scales with how important and how exam-tested the concept is** — not a fixed number for every subtopic. Countable/uncountable nouns, for instance, gets a very large bank because it is genuinely one of the highest-yield confusion areas in English for exam purposes; something narrower gets a proportionately smaller (but still thorough) bank.

**A note on scope:** This Part A covers Chapter 0 (Foundations) and Chapter 1 (the complete Noun system) at full depth. Verbs, Tenses, Pronouns, Adjectives/Adverbs, Prepositions, and the rest of the Level 0–9 syllabus continue in Part B onward, built to this same standard.

# CHAPTER 0 — FOUNDATIONS: WHAT IS A SENTENCE?

Learning objectives: recognise a complete sentence, identify subject and predicate in sentences of increasing complexity, classify sentences by function, and avoid the two most common structural errors (fragments and run-ons).

## 0.1 What Is a Word, and What Is a Sentence?

**A word** is the smallest unit of language that carries meaning on its own. **A sentence** is a group of words that expresses a complete thought and can stand alone. That's the entire test: does it feel finished, or does it leave you waiting for more?

**Complete thought (a sentence):** The soldier saluted.  
**Incomplete thought (not a sentence):** Because the soldier  
*Notice how "Because the soldier" makes you wait — your mind expects "...saluted" or "...was late" or something to finish it. That waiting feeling is the signal that a group of words is NOT yet a sentence.*

Why does this matter? Because in English, a sentence is built around a minimum skeleton: **someone/something doing or being something**. That skeleton has two parts, and every sentence in this book — no matter how long or complicated — can be broken down into these two parts.

## 0.2 Subject and Predicate

**Subject:** who or what the sentence is about.  
**Predicate:** what is said about the subject (usually contains the verb).

| Sentence                                                                             | Subject                                 | Predicate                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| The dog barks.                                                                       | The dog                                 | barks                                       |
| Ravi is a pilot.                                                                     | Ravi                                    | is a pilot                                  |
| The old bridge collapsed suddenly.                                                   | The old bridge                          | collapsed suddenly                          |
| All the recruits in the third battalion completed the obstacle course before sunset. | All the recruits in the third battalion | completed the obstacle course before sunset |

**How to find the subject:** Ask "who or what [verb]?" For "The old bridge collapsed suddenly," ask "who or what collapsed?" → "The old bridge." That's your subject.

**How to find the predicate:** Everything that is not the subject. It always contains the main verb.

### Progressive Examples — Subject/Predicate Identification

Level 1 — Easy

- Birds fly. → Subject: *Birds* | Predicate: *fly*
- She sings. → Subject: *She* | Predicate: *sings*
- Rain fell. → Subject: *Rain* | Predicate: *fell*
- The child laughed. → Subject: *The child* | Predicate: *laughed*
- My brother works. → Subject: *My brother* | Predicate: *works*

Level 2 — Beginner

- The tall soldier marched confidently. → Subject: *The tall soldier* | Predicate: *marched confidently*
- Our new commander arrived yesterday. → Subject: *Our new commander* | Predicate: *arrived yesterday*
- The entire village celebrated the festival. → Subject: *The entire village* | Predicate: *celebrated the festival*
- Two large trucks blocked the narrow road. → Subject: *Two large trucks* | Predicate: *blocked the narrow road*

Level 3 — Intermediate

- The general, along with his aides, inspected the camp. → Subject: *The general* (the phrase "along with his aides" is an

added detail, not part of the grammatical subject — this becomes important later when we study subject-verb agreement) | Predicate: *inspected the camp*

11. Running through the fields, the children shouted with joy. → Subject: *the children* | Predicate: *shouted with joy* (the opening phrase describes the subject but is not the subject itself)

12. What he said surprised everyone. → Subject: *What he said* (a whole clause acting as the subject!) | Predicate: *surprised everyone*

**Note on Example 12:** Don't panic if the subject is not a single noun — it can be an entire clause. We will study this in depth in the chapter on clauses. For now, just recognise: whatever answers "who or what [verb]?" is the subject, however long it is.

### 0.3 The Four Sentence Types (By Function)

| Type          | Purpose                  | End Punctuation                  | Examples                                                         |
|---------------|--------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Declarative   | Makes a statement        | Full stop (.)                    | The exam is on Sunday.<br>He has already left.                   |
| Interrogative | Asks a question          | Question mark (?)                | Is the exam on Sunday?<br>Has he left already?                   |
| Imperative    | Gives a command/request  | Full stop (.) or exclamation (!) | Close the door.<br>Report to the commanding officer immediately! |
| Exclamatory   | Expresses strong feeling | Exclamation mark (!)             | What a magnificent view!<br>We won the match!                    |

- Mixed identification practice:**
- 1. Where is the nearest railway station? — *Interrogative*
  - 2. Please submit your form by Friday. — *Imperative*
  - 3. The monsoon arrived early this year. — *Declarative*
  - 4. What a disaster that was! — *Exclamatory*
  - 5. Stand at ease! — *Imperative* (note: can take an exclamation mark for emphasis, especially in commands/military contexts)
  - 6. Did you complete the assignment? — *Interrogative*
  - 7. I can't believe we finished on time! — *Exclamatory*
  - 8. The train departs at six in the morning. — *Declarative*

#### Common Confusion: Imperative sentences and the "hidden subject"

Imperative sentences look like they have no subject: "Close the door." But the subject is understood to be "you" — the person being addressed. This is called an **understood subject** or "you (understood)." This matters later when we discuss commands in reported speech (e.g., "He told me to close the door" — the "you" becomes "me").

### 0.4 A First Look at Phrases and Clauses

You will meet these terms constantly, so a working definition now will save confusion later (we return to this in full depth in the Clauses chapter):

- Phrase:** a group of related words that does NOT contain both a subject and a verb, and does not express a complete thought by itself. Example: "*in the morning*," "*the tall soldier*," "*running quickly*."
- Clause:** a group of words that DOES contain both a subject and a verb. A clause may or may not be a complete sentence on its own.

- Phrase examples:** under the bridge • a box of chocolates • having finished the work • to become an officer
- Clause examples:** because he was late (has subject "he" + verb "was," but is NOT a complete sentence by itself) • the train arrived (has subject + verb, AND is a complete sentence)

## 0.5 Common Mistakes: Fragments and Run-Ons

**Sentence Fragment:** a group of words punctuated like a sentence but missing a subject, a verb, or expressing an incomplete thought.

✗ **Because he missed the bus.** (incomplete — leaves you waiting for the result)

✓ **He missed the bus, so he was late.**

✗ **Running across the field in the rain.** (no subject-verb combination forming a complete thought)

✓ **She was running across the field in the rain.**

✗ **The soldier who guarded the gate all night.** (this is a subject with a describing clause, but no main verb for "the soldier" — it never says what he did)

✓ **The soldier who guarded the gate all night finally went home.**

**Run-on Sentence:** two or more complete sentences incorrectly joined without proper punctuation or connecting words.

✗ **The rain stopped the sun came out.**

✓ **The rain stopped, and the sun came out.**

✓ **The rain stopped. The sun came out.**

✓ **The rain stopped; the sun came out.**

✗ **He studied hard he still failed the test.**

✓ **He studied hard, but he still failed the test.**

**Exam Trap:** Sentence-correction questions frequently hide a comma splice — two complete sentences joined by only a comma with no connecting word. Example: "**She finished her work, she went home.**" is technically a run-on (comma splice). The fix: add a connector ("she finished her work, **and** she went home"), use a semicolon, or split into two sentences.

## Practice Set 0 — Foundations (30 Questions)

### Part A: Identify Subject and Predicate (1-10)

1. The old clock stopped ticking at midnight.
2. Several villagers gathered near the temple.
3. My uncle, a retired colonel, visits us every winter.
4. The bridge across the river was destroyed in the flood.
5. Anyone who breaks the rule will be punished.
6. The exhausted climbers finally reached the summit.
7. A loud explosion shook the entire building.
8. What you did was completely unacceptable.
9. The committee, after much debate, rejected the proposal.
10. Slowly and carefully, the technician defused the device.

#### Answers:

1. Subject: The old clock | Predicate: stopped ticking at midnight
2. Subject: Several villagers | Predicate: gathered near the temple
3. Subject: My uncle, a retired colonel | Predicate: visits us every winter
4. Subject: The bridge across the river | Predicate: was destroyed in the flood
5. Subject: Anyone who breaks the rule | Predicate: will be punished
6. Subject: The exhausted climbers | Predicate: finally reached the summit
7. Subject: A loud explosion | Predicate: shook the entire building
8. Subject: What you did | Predicate: was completely unacceptable
9. Subject: The committee | Predicate: after much debate, rejected the proposal
10. Subject: the technician | Predicate: slowly and carefully defused the device

### Part B: Classify by Sentence Type (11-20)

11. Shut the window at once!
12. Why did you leave without informing anyone?
13. The report was submitted on time.
14. What a relief that was!
15. Please hand over your identification.
16. The convoy will depart at dawn.
17. Has the shipment arrived yet?
18. Never speak to me like that again!
19. The lecture covered three main topics.
20. Could you please repeat the instructions?

**Answers:** 11. Imperative 12. Interrogative 13. Declarative 14. Exclamatory 15. Imperative 16. Declarative 17. Interrogative 18. Exclamatory/Imperative (a forceful command — acceptable as either, but most graders will mark Imperative since it is a command; the exclamation mark only signals emphasis) 19. Declarative 20. Interrogative

### Part C: Fragment, Run-on, or Correct? (21–30)

21. Although the weather was terrible.
22. The plan failed we tried again.
23. She locked the door and left.
24. Running as fast as he could.
25. The results were announced, everyone cheered.
26. Because it was raining, the match was postponed.
27. The soldiers stood at attention.
28. Tired and hungry, but determined to finish.
29. He apologised sincerely, and she forgave him.
30. The manager left early nobody knew why.

**Answers:**

21. Fragment (subordinate clause with no main clause — needs something like "...the match continued.")
22. Run-on (comma splice — needs "The plan failed, so we tried again" or a full stop)
23. Correct
24. Fragment (no subject stated, no complete main verb structure — needs "He was running as fast as he could.")
25. Run-on (comma splice — needs "The results were announced, and everyone cheered.")
26. Correct
27. Correct
28. Fragment ("but determined to finish" has no subject/verb of its own — needs "He was tired and hungry but determined to finish.")
29. Correct
30. Run-on (needs "The manager left early, and nobody knew why" or a semicolon)

## Mastery Check — Chapter 0

Before moving to Chapter 1, you should be able to, without hesitation:

- Identify the subject and predicate of any sentence, including ones with long subjects or clauses as subjects.
- Classify any sentence as declarative, interrogative, imperative, or exclamatory.
- Explain the difference between a phrase and a clause in your own words.
- Spot a sentence fragment and correct it.
- Spot a run-on sentence (including comma splices) and correct it in at least two different ways.

If any of these feel shaky, redo Practice Set 0 before continuing — this foundation is used in every remaining chapter.

# CHAPTER 1 — THE COMPLETE NOUN SYSTEM

This chapter is deliberately the longest and most detailed in Part A. Nouns are the foundation on which pronouns, articles, determiners, subject-verb agreement, and much of sentence analysis are built — a shaky understanding here creates problems in every later chapter.

## 1.1 What Is a Noun?

A **noun** is a word that names a person, place, thing, animal, idea, quality, or state. If you can put "the," "a/an," or "some" in front of a word (in at least some context) and it still makes sense, it is very likely a noun.

### Why does the category "noun" exist?

Language needs a way to refer to the "things" a sentence is about — the people acting, the objects being acted upon, the places events happen in, and even the ideas being discussed. Nouns are the labels for all of these. Without nouns, you could not name anything: no "soldier," no "India," no "courage," no "team."

### How to recognise a noun (identification tests)

1. **The article test:** Can you put "a," "an," or "the" before it? *a soldier, the courage, an idea* — all pass.
2. **The plural test:** Can you (usually) add "-s" or "-es" to show more than one? *soldier→soldiers, idea→ideas*. (Not all nouns pass this — we'll see why in section 1.5.)
3. **The possessive test:** Can you add "'s" to show ownership? *the soldier's rifle, India's history*.
4. **The position test:** Nouns typically fill the "who/what" slot — the subject or object position in a sentence.

### Progressive Examples — Recognising Nouns

**Level 1 — Easy** Identify the noun(s):

1. The dog barked. → *dog*
2. Priya reads books. → *Priya, books*
3. The sun is bright. → *sun*
4. Children play outside. → *Children*
5. He bought a car. → *car*

**Level 2 — Beginner** Identify all nouns:

6. The teacher gave the students a difficult assignment. → *teacher, students, assignment*
7. Courage is essential for a soldier. → *Courage, soldier* (note: "courage" is a noun even though it names a quality, not a physical thing — more on this in 1.3)
8. The committee announced its decision yesterday. → *committee, decision* ("yesterday" here functions as an adverb of time, not a noun, though it can be a noun in other contexts — e.g., "Yesterday was a holiday.")
9. Honesty and hard work lead to success. → *Honesty, work, success*

**Level 3 — Intermediate** Identify all nouns (harder — some words can be more than one part of speech):

10. The running of the bulls attracts thousands of tourists. → *running* (here it's a noun — "the running," with an article before it!), *bulls, thousands, tourists*
11. His fast thinking saved the mission. → *thinking* (noun here — "his...thinking"), *mission* ("fast" here is an adjective describing "thinking")
12. Light travels faster than sound. → *Light, sound* (both nouns here, though "light" can also be a verb or adjective in other sentences)

**Important early insight:** Examples 10–12 reveal something crucial: **the same word can be a noun in one sentence and a different part of speech in another.** "Running," "light," and "fast" are not fixed categories — their grammatical identity depends on how they function in that specific sentence. This idea (a word's function, not its form, determines its part of speech) will come back constantly throughout this course.

### Non-Examples: What Is NOT a Noun (Even Though It Might Look Like One)

1. *Quickly* she left. → NOT a noun (adverb — describes how she left; fails the article test: "the quickly" is meaningless)

2. She is *beautiful*. → NOT a noun (adjective, describes "she"); but "beauty" (the related noun) IS a noun: "Her *beauty* is well known."

3. He *runs* every day. → NOT a noun here (verb, main action); but "a run" or "the running" would be nouns: "He went for a *run*."

4. They live *near* the station. → NOT a noun (preposition, shows relationship/position)

## 1.2 Common Nouns vs. Proper Nouns

- Common noun:** names a general, non-specific person, place, or thing — one of a class or category. Not capitalised (unless it starts a sentence).

**Proper noun:** names one specific, unique person, place, organisation, or thing. Always capitalised.

| Common Noun (general) | Proper Noun (specific/unique)    |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------|
| country               | India, Japan, Brazil             |
| river                 | the Ganga, the Nile, the Amazon  |
| city                  | Mumbai, Paris, Tokyo             |
| academy               | the Indian Military Academy      |
| book                  | the Bhagavad Gita, War and Peace |
| month                 | September, December              |
| language              | Hindi, English, Tamil            |
| festival              | Diwali, Christmas, Eid           |
| company               | Tata, Infosys, Google            |
| mountain              | Kangchenjunga, Mount Everest     |

### Tricky Cases: When the Same Word Can Be Both

1. "The president will address the nation." (common — refers to the role in general)  
"President Kalam was widely respected." (proper — refers to the specific title+name)

2. "My uncle is visiting." (common)  
"I told Uncle Ravi the news." (proper — "Uncle" here functions as part of a name/title)

3. "We study geography in school." (common)  
"He teaches Geography and History." (school subject names are often capitalised as proper nouns in this specific "subject title" use — usage varies; many style guides keep these lowercase unless part of an official course title, e.g. "History 101")

4. "The army was deployed." (common)  
"The Indian Army conducted the exercise." (proper — specific named institution)

### Common Mistakes with Common/Proper Nouns

- ✗ my Father works in Delhi.** — "Father" is capitalised here for no reason (it's a common noun in this sentence, not used as a name).  
**✓ My father works in Delhi.**

**✓ I asked Father for permission.** (correct — here "Father" is being used AS a name/direct address, so capitalisation is appropriate)
- ✗ i visited india last Summer.**  
**✓ I visited India last summer.** (Note: "I" is always capitalised as a pronoun — a separate rule; "India" is a proper noun and must be capitalised; "summer" is a common noun here and should NOT be capitalised)

### Practice — Common or Proper? (20 items)



Classify each underlined noun as Common (C) or Proper (P):

1. The captain gave the order.   2. Captain Mehta gave the order.   3. We visited a museum.   4. We visited the National War Memorial.   5. She studies chemistry.   6. He was born in February.   7. The river flooded the plains.   8. The Brahmaputra flooded the plains.   9. My school is nearby.   10. Delhi Public School is nearby.   11. He works for a company.   12. He works for Infosys.   13. The festival was colourful.   14. Diwali was colourful.   15. She reads a newspaper daily.   16. She reads The Hindu daily.   17. The ocean is vast.   18. The Pacific Ocean is vast.   19. He admires his teacher.   20. He admires Dr. Kalam.

**Answers:** 1-C, 2-P, 3-C, 4-P, 5-C, 6-P, 7-C, 8-P, 9-C, 10-P, 11-C, 12-P, 13-C, 14-P, 15-C, 16-P, 17-C, 18-P, 19-C, 20-P

### 1.3 Concrete Nouns vs. Abstract Nouns

**Concrete noun:** names something you can perceive with your five senses — see, hear, touch, taste, or smell.  
**Abstract noun:** names an idea, quality, feeling, or state that has no physical form.

| Concrete Nouns                                                            | Abstract Nouns                                                                             |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| table, mountain, dog, rifle, coin, thunder, perfume, cake, uniform, river | courage, honesty, freedom, happiness, justice, anger, wisdom, patience, loyalty, democracy |

#### How Abstract Nouns Are Often Formed

Many abstract nouns are formed from adjectives or verbs using suffixes — this is a preview of noun formation (fully covered in section 1.13):

happy → happi**ness** | honest → honest**y** | brave → brav**ery** | free → freed**om** | just → just**ice** | wise → wis**dom** | act → acti**on** | decide → decisi**on** | friend → friend**ship** | child → child**hood**

#### Tricky/Edge Cases: Words That Can Be Concrete or Abstract

Some words shift between concrete and abstract depending on meaning — a very important CDS-style distinction:

- 1. beauty**  
Abstract: "Her beauty impressed everyone." (the quality)  
Concrete (rare, poetic/plural use): "The garden was full of natural beauties." (specific beautiful things/sights)
- 2. art**  
Abstract: "Art reflects culture." (the general concept)  
Concrete: "The museum displayed several arts from the region." (actual art pieces — though many style guides prefer "artworks" here; "the arts" as plural often refers to fields of art collectively)
- 3. experience**  
Abstract/uncountable: "He has a lot of experience." (accumulated knowledge — cannot be counted: not "an experience" here)  
Concrete-ish/countable: "That was an unforgettable experience." (a specific event — now countable: "several experiences")  
*This exact example returns in section 1.5, since it's really a countable/uncountable distinction wearing a concrete/abstract costume.*
- 4. youth**  
Abstract: "Youth is a time of energy." (the life stage/quality)  
Concrete (collective, refers to people): "The youth of the country must be empowered." (young people as a group)
- 5. sight**  
Abstract: "He lost his sight." (the sense/ability)  
Concrete: "The Taj Mahal is a magnificent sight." (a specific thing seen)

#### Identification Practice — Concrete or Abstract? (25 items)

1. courage 2. table 3. freedom 4. mountain 5. justice 6. rifle 7. happiness 8. thunder 9. wisdom 10. perfume 11. loyalty 12. cake 13. democracy 14. uniform 15. anger 16. river 17. patience 18. coin 19. friendship 20. childhood 21. bravery 22. sunlight 23. honesty 24. bridge 25. peace

**Answers:** Concrete: 2,4,6,8,10,12,14,16,18,22,24. Abstract: 1,3,5,7,9,11,13,15,17,19,20,21,23,25.

## 1.4 Collective Nouns

**Collective noun:** names a group of people, animals, or things treated as a single unit.

**People:** team, family, jury, committee, staff, crowd, audience, class, band, crew, army, government, cabinet, panel, board, congregation

**Animals:** herd (cattle/elephants), flock (sheep/birds), pack (wolves/dogs), swarm (bees/insects), shoal/school (fish), pride (lions), pod (whales/dolphins), colony (ants), troop (monkeys)

**Things:** fleet (ships), bunch (flowers/keys/grapes), bundle (sticks/clothes), cluster (stars/grapes), collection (stamps), set (tools), range (mountains), forest (trees), library (books)

### Collective Noun Agreement — Singular or Plural Verb?

This is one of the most-tested collective noun rules. The choice depends on whether the group is acting **as one unit** (singular verb) or its **members are acting individually** (plural verb — more common in British English than American English).

#### Acting as a single unit → singular verb:

"The team is practising for tomorrow's match." (one unit, practising together)

"The committee has approved the budget." (acted as one decision-making body)

"My family is large." (a description of the family as a whole)

#### Members acting/thinking individually → plural verb (especially British usage):

"The team are arguing among themselves about strategy." (individuals disagreeing)

"The committee are divided on the issue." (members hold different opinions)

"My family are all doctors." (each member individually is a doctor)

**For CDS/AFCAT purposes:** American English convention (generally followed in Indian competitive exams) almost always treats collective nouns as **singular** unless there's a very clear signal of individual, disagreeing action. When in doubt on the exam, choose the singular verb form for a collective noun.

### Practice — Collective Noun Verb Agreement (15 items)

Choose the correct verb:

1. The jury (has/have) reached a verdict.
2. The audience (was/were) cheering loudly.
3. The government (has/have) announced new policies.
4. A herd of elephants (was/were) crossing the highway.
5. The staff (is/are) required to attend the meeting.
6. The army (was/were) mobilised within hours.
7. The class (is/are) preparing for the annual function.
8. The board of directors (has/have) approved the merger.
9. The flock of birds (was/were) flying south.
10. Our team (has/have) won the tournament three times.
11. The crowd (was/were) growing restless.
12. The cabinet (meets/meet) every Monday.
13. The orchestra (plays/play) beautifully together.
14. The panel of judges (has/have) disagreed on the winner.
15. The crew (is/are) preparing for departure.

**Answers:** 1. has 2. was (unit reacting together; "were" also acceptable if emphasising individuals) 3. has 4. was 5. are (staff, like police, often takes plural agreement as it refers to individual staff members collectively — treat as an exception to note) 6. was 7. is 8. has 9. was 10. has 11. was 12. meets 13. plays 14. have (disagreement signals individuals) 15. is

## 1.5 Countable Nouns vs. Uncountable Nouns

This is one of the single highest-value grammar distinctions in English for both everyday accuracy and competitive exams — it governs which quantity words you can use (much/many, a/an, few/little), whether a noun can be plural, and which verb form follows it. It deserves — and gets — the largest example bank in this chapter.

**Countable noun:** refers to something that can be counted as a separate, individual unit. Has a singular and plural form (one book, two books). Can follow "a/an" and numbers.

**Uncountable noun** (also called a **mass noun**): refers to something viewed as a whole, substance, or general concept rather than separate units. Has no plural form in standard use. Cannot follow "a/an" or a number directly. Always takes a singular verb.

### A. Basic Countable Nouns — Singular/Plural Pairs

book / books

chair / chairs

student / students

pen / pens

car / cars

dog / dogs

apple / apples

city / cities

idea / ideas

question / questions

friend / friends

mountain / mountains

bottle / bottles

phone / phones

table / tables

officer / officers

soldier / soldiers

exam / exams

lesson / lessons

country / countries

All of these can be directly counted: "one book, two books, three books" — and all can follow "a/an" in the singular: "a book," "a student," "an idea."

### B. Uncountable Nouns — Organised Word Bank

#### Abstract concepts:

information

advice

knowledge

wisdom

honesty

courage

happiness

education

research

progress  
evidence  
permission  
access  
behaviour  
luck  
fun  
news

**Substances and materials:**

water  
milk  
rice  
sugar  
salt  
flour  
oil  
gold  
silver  
iron  
wood  
cotton  
wool  
air  
gas  
electricity  
sand  
petrol

**General collections (no individual "unit" implied):**

furniture  
luggage  
baggage  
equipment  
machinery  
jewellery  
clothing  
cutlery  
traffic  
garbage  
rubbish  
scenery  
homework  
software

**Weather and natural phenomena:**

weather  
rain  
snow  
thunder  
lightning  
sunshine  
fog  
humidity

### Others:

money  
bread  
toast  
spaghetti  
music  
chess  
tennis  
football (the sport)

**Why "furniture" has no plural:** A chair, a table, and a sofa are each individually countable ("chairs," "tables"), but "furniture" is the general category label — English treats the category itself as a single mass, not a countable unit. This is the pattern behind most uncountable "collection" nouns: luggage (bags, suitcases), equipment (tools, machines), jewellery (rings, necklaces) — the general category is uncountable even though its members are individually countable.

## C. Tricky Words: Same Word, Different Behaviour by Meaning

This is where most learners (and most exam distractors) go wrong. The SAME word can be countable in one meaning and uncountable in another. Study each pair carefully — the meaning shift is the key.

### 1. experience

Uncountable (accumulated knowledge/skill): "He has a lot of experience in teaching." / "Do you have any experience with this software?"

Countable (a specific event that happened to you): "That was an unforgettable experience." / "She shared some frightening experiences from the war."

### 2. paper

Uncountable (the material): "I need some paper to wrap this gift." / "This is made of recycled paper."

Countable (a document / newspaper / academic article / exam): "Submit your papers by Friday." / "I read the paper every morning." / "She published a paper on climate change." / "The Maths paper was difficult this year."

### 3. light

Uncountable (illumination in general): "There isn't enough light in this room to read."

Countable (a specific lamp/fixture/signal): "Turn off the lights before you leave." / "Stop at the red light."

### 4. time

Uncountable (the general concept/resource): "I don't have time for this today." / "Time heals all wounds."

Countable (an occurrence/instance, or an idiomatic "occasion"): "I've told you many times already." / "We had a wonderful time at the party." (this idiomatic "a good/great time" uses "time" as if it were countable, meaning "experience/occasion")

### 5. work

Uncountable (labour/employment/effort): "She has a lot of work to finish today." / "He is looking for work."

Countable (a creative piece — art, literature, music; plural "works"): "The museum displayed the works of famous painters." / "This is one of Shakespeare's greatest works."

### 6. room

Uncountable (space/capacity): "There isn't enough room in this bag for another book."

Countable (a chamber within a building): "The house has five rooms."

### 7. chicken

Uncountable (the meat, as food): "I had chicken for dinner."

Countable (the live animal): "The farmer keeps ten chickens."

### 8. coffee

Uncountable (the substance/drink in general): "I love coffee in the morning."

Countable (an order/serving, i.e. "a cup of"): "Two coffees, please." / "I'll have a coffee."

### 9. hair

Uncountable (collectively, on the head): "She has beautiful, long hair." (NEVER "hairs" for this general sense)

Countable (individual strands): "I found a hair in my soup." / "He has a few grey hairs."

### 10. glass

Uncountable (the material): "The window is made of glass."

Countable, meaning 1 (a drinking vessel): "Pour me a glass of water." / "The glasses are in the cupboard."

Countable, meaning 2 (spectacles — always plural in this sense): "He wears glasses for reading."

### 11. business

Uncountable (commerce/trade in general): "Business is booming this year." / "He's here on business."

Countable (a specific company/enterprise): "He runs three businesses in the city."

### 12. iron

Uncountable (the metal): "The gate is made of iron."

Countable (the appliance for pressing clothes): "I need to buy a new iron; mine broke."

### 13. wood

Uncountable (the material): "The table is made of wood."

Countable, usually plural (a small forest): "They went for a walk in the woods."

### 14. fish

As food (uncountable): "We had fish for dinner."

As the living animal (countable, but note: the plural form is usually the SAME as the singular — "fish," not "fishes," when referring to multiple fish of the same kind): "He caught three fish." ("fishes" is used only when referring to multiple species/kinds of fish — a rare, technical use.)

### 15. stone

Uncountable (the material): "The old fort is built of stone."

Countable, meaning 1 (a piece of rock): "A child threw a stone at the wall."

Countable, meaning 2 (a gem): "Her ring has a beautiful blue stone."

Countable, meaning 3 (a British unit of weight = 14 lb): "He weighs eleven stone." (note: unusually, "stone" as this unit doesn't take "-s" even after a number — a genuine exception worth remembering for reading British texts)

### 16. fruit

Uncountable, general sense (the food category as a whole): "Eat more fruit; it's good for you." (NOT "fruits" in this everyday general sense in most standard usage)

Countable, when referring to different kinds/varieties: "Tropical fruits like mango and papaya grow well here."

### 17. cake / chocolate

Uncountable (the substance, a portion of it): "Would you like some cake?" / "I love chocolate."

Countable (a whole baked item / an individual piece of candy): "She baked a cake for the party." / "I bought a box of chocolates."

### 18. ability / capacity

Uncountable (the general capability): "He has the ability to lead under pressure."

Countable, plural (specific individual skills): "He has many abilities, including public speaking and negotiation."

## D. Expressing Quantity with Uncountable Nouns (Partitives / Measure Words)

Since you cannot say "an information" or "two rice," English uses special "measure words" or "partitive" expressions to count a portion or unit of an uncountable noun.

| Uncountable Noun | How to Express a Unit/Portion of It          |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| information      | a piece of information, a bit of information |
| advice           | a piece of advice                            |
| news             | a piece of news, an item of news             |
| bread            | a loaf of bread, a slice of bread            |
| cake             | a slice/piece of cake                        |
| coffee/tea       | a cup of coffee                              |
| chocolate        | a bar of chocolate                           |
| rice             | a grain of rice, a bowl of rice              |
| clothing         | an item/article of clothing                  |
| furniture        | a piece/item of furniture                    |
| applause         | a round of applause                          |
| luggage          | a piece of luggage                           |
| work             | a piece of work, a task                      |
| research         | a piece of research, a study                 |

### E. Quantifiers: Which Ones Go With Which Type

| Quantifier                          | With Countable (plural)                         | With Uncountable                                 |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| much                                | ✗                                               | ✓ How much water?                                |
| many                                | ✓ How many books?                               | ✗                                                |
| a few                               | ✓ a few friends (some, a small positive number) | ✗                                                |
| few                                 | ✓ few friends (almost none, negative tone)      | ✗                                                |
| a little                            | ✗                                               | ✓ a little money (some, a small positive amount) |
| little                              | ✗                                               | ✓ little money (almost none, negative tone)      |
| some / any                          | ✓ some books / any books                        | ✓ some water / any water                         |
| a lot of / lots of / plenty of      | ✓                                               | ✓                                                |
| several                             | ✓ several ideas                                 | ✗                                                |
| each / every                        | ✓ (singular form) each book                     | ✗                                                |
| a number of                         | ✓ a number of complaints                        | ✗                                                |
| a great deal of / a large amount of | ✗                                               | ✓ a great deal of effort                         |

**Exam Trap:** "Few" vs "a few" and "little" vs "a little" is one of the most frequently tested distinctions. **Adding "a" flips the meaning from negative to positive:**

**He has few friends, so he is happy and popular.** ✗ (illogical — "few friends" means almost no friends, which contradicts "popular")

**He has a few friends, so he is happy and popular.** ✓ (a few = some, a small but adequate number — this makes logical sense)

**He has few friends, so he often feels lonely.** ✓ (few = almost none — this fits "lonely")

### Common Mistakes with Countable/Uncountable Nouns (Top 12)

✗ I need an advice. → ✓ I need some advice. / I need a piece of advice. ("advice" is uncountable — never "an advice")

or "advices")

✗ **She has many informations.** → ✔ **She has a lot of information.** ("information" has no plural form)

✗ **I bought a furniture.** → ✔ **I bought a piece of furniture. / I bought some furniture.**

✗ **How much books do you have?** → ✔ **How many books do you have?** ("books" is countable — use "many," not "much")

✗ **There is few water left.** → ✔ **There is little water left.** ("water" is uncountable — use "little," not "few," and note the singular verb "is")

✗ **I have less friends than her.** → ✔ **I have fewer friends than her.** ("friends" is countable — use "fewer," not "less"; "less" is for uncountable nouns: "less money," "less time")

✗ **He gave me many advices.** → ✔ **He gave me a lot of advice. / He gave me several pieces of advice.**

✗ **The news are good today.** → ✔ **The news is good today.** ("news" looks plural but is grammatically singular — always takes a singular verb, a classic exam trap)

✗ **I need a luggage for the trip.** → ✔ **I need some luggage / a piece of luggage for the trip.**

✗ **She has beautiful hairs.** → ✔ **She has beautiful hair.** ("hair" collectively on the head is uncountable — "hairs" only refers to individual, countable strands)

✗ **I did a lot of homeworks.** → ✔ **I did a lot of homework.** ("homework" has no plural form)

✗ **We don't have much chairs.** → ✔ **We don't have many chairs.**

## Practice Set 1.5 — Countable vs. Uncountable (50 Questions Across 4 Parts)

### Part A: Countable or Uncountable? (1-15)

Classify each noun as Countable (C) or Uncountable (U):

1. information 2. chair 3. music 4. idea 5. furniture 6. book 7. advice 8. luggage 9. student 10. bread 11. knowledge 12. mountain 13. equipment 14. news 15. question

**Answers:** 1-U, 2-C, 3-U, 4-C, 5-U, 6-C, 7-U, 8-U, 9-C, 10-U, 11-U, 12-C, 13-U, 14-U, 15-C

### Part B: Choose "much" or "many" / "few" or "little" (16-30)

16. How \_\_\_\_\_ time do we have left? 17. How \_\_\_\_\_ chairs do we need? 18. There are too \_\_\_\_\_ mistakes in this report. 19. There isn't \_\_\_\_\_ sugar in the jar. 20. She has \_\_\_\_\_ friends in this city (almost none). 21. He has \_\_\_\_\_ friends here (a small but adequate number). 22. We have \_\_\_\_\_ money left (almost none). 23. We have \_\_\_\_\_ money left, so we can still eat out (a small but adequate amount). 24. There are too \_\_\_\_\_ people in this room. 25. There is too \_\_\_\_\_ noise here. 26. I don't have \_\_\_\_\_ experience in this field. 27. I have \_\_\_\_\_ questions to ask you (several). 28. She showed \_\_\_\_\_ interest in the topic (almost none). 29. He gave \_\_\_\_\_ useful suggestions. 30. How \_\_\_\_\_ water should I add?

**Answers:** 16. much 17. many 18. many 19. much 20. few 21. a few 22. little 23. a little 24. many 25. much 26. much 27. many/a few 28. little 29. many 30. much

### Part C: Tricky Word — Choose the Correct Meaning/Form (31-40)



31. I need \_\_\_\_\_ (paper/a paper) to wrap this present. 32. She's writing \_\_\_\_\_ (paper/a paper) on renewable energy for her thesis. 33. Could I have \_\_\_\_\_ (a coffee/coffee) — just one cup, please? 34. \_\_\_\_\_ (Coffee/A coffee) is grown mainly in tropical regions. 35. This bridge is built of \_\_\_\_\_ (stone/a stone). 36. A child threw \_\_\_\_\_ (stone/a stone) through the window. 37. He has a lot of \_\_\_\_\_ (experience/experiences) managing large teams. 38. She told us about her \_\_\_\_\_ (experience/experiences) travelling through Africa. 39. There isn't enough \_\_\_\_\_ (room/rooms) in the car for everyone. 40. This apartment has three \_\_\_\_\_ (room/rooms).

**Answers:** 31. paper 32. a paper 33. a coffee 34. Coffee 35. stone 36. a stone 37. experience 38. experiences 39. room 40. rooms

Part D: Error Correction (41-50)

Find and correct the error in each sentence:

41. I need an advice about my career.

42. She gave me many informations about the course.

43. There are less students in this class than last year.

44. He has few good friends, so he never feels lonely. (logic check — does this sentence make sense as written?)

45. The news are shocking.

46. I bought two furnitures for the new house.

47. How much books did you read this year?

48. We don't have many time before the train leaves.

49. She has beautiful hairs.

50. I did many homeworks last night.

**Answers:**

41. "an advice" → "some advice" / "a piece of advice"

42. "many informations" → "a lot of information"

43. "less students" → "fewer students" (students is countable)

44. Logic error: "few" (almost none) contradicts "never feels lonely" — should be "a few good friends" for the sentence to make sense

45. "The news are" → "The news is" (always singular)

46. "two furnitures" → "two pieces of furniture"

47. "How much books" → "How many books" (books is countable)

48. "many time" → "much time" (time is uncountable here)

49. "beautiful hairs" → "beautiful hair"

50. "many homeworks" → "a lot of homework" / "much homework"

# 1.6 Singular and Plural Nouns

English plural formation looks simple ("just add -s") until you meet the dozens of nouns that don't follow that rule. This section builds the complete picture: regular rules, irregular forms you must memorise, borrowed (foreign) plurals, nouns with no separate plural form, plural-only nouns, and — a favourite exam trap — nouns that look plural but are grammatically singular.

## A. Regular Plural Rules

| Rule                                                      | Examples                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Most nouns: add <b>-s</b>                                 | cat→cats, book→books, table→tables, idea→ideas                                                            |
| Nouns ending in -s, -ss, -x, -z, -ch, -sh: add <b>-es</b> | bus→buses, class→classes, box→boxes, buzz→buzzes, church→churches, brush→brushes                          |
| Consonant + y: change <b>y→i</b> , add <b>-es</b>         | city→cities, baby→babies, country→countries, army→armies                                                  |
| Vowel + y: just add <b>-s</b> (no change)                 | boy→boys, day→days, key→keys, toy→toys                                                                    |
| Many nouns ending in -f/-fe: change to <b>-ves</b>        | leaf→leaves, knife→knives, wife→wives, life→lives, wolf→wolves, half→halves, shelf→shelves, thief→thieves |
|                                                           |                                                                                                           |

|                                                                                   |                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Exceptions to the -f/-fe rule: just add <b>-s</b>                                 | roof→roofs, chief→chiefs, belief→beliefs, cliff→cliffs, safe→safes, proof→proofs |
| Some nouns ending in -o: add <b>-es</b>                                           | potato→potatoes, tomato→tomatoes, hero→heroes, echo→echoes, mango→mangoes        |
| Other nouns ending in -o (often loanwords/musical/tech terms): just add <b>-s</b> | photo→photos, piano→pianos, radio→radios, video→videos, logo→logos, kilo→kilos   |

B. Irregular Plurals (Must Be Memorised — No Rule Predicts These)

- man → men
- woman → women
- child → children
- foot → feet
- tooth → teeth
- goose → geese
- mouse → mice
- person → people
- ox → oxen
- louse → lice

**Pronunciation trap:** "Woman" (singular) is pronounced *WUM-un*, but "women" (plural) is pronounced *WIM-in* — the vowel sound changes even though only one letter changes in spelling. This is occasionally tested in listening/reading-based competitive questions.

C. Foreign (Latin/Greek) Plurals

English borrowed many academic and scientific words from Latin and Greek, and some keep their original plural forms — though many now also accept a regular English plural in everyday use.

| Singular   | Plural (Original)          | Note                                                                                                                                   |
|------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| criterion  | criteria                   | "Criteria" is plural — "the criteria are," never "the criteria is"                                                                     |
| phenomenon | phenomena                  | Same pattern: "these phenomena are..."                                                                                                 |
| datum      | data                       | Traditionally "data" is plural ("the data are conclusive"), though singular usage is increasingly common informally                    |
| analysis   | analyses                   | -is → -es for this whole family of words                                                                                               |
| crisis     | crises                     | Same pattern                                                                                                                           |
| thesis     | theses                     | Same pattern                                                                                                                           |
| hypothesis | hypotheses                 | Same pattern                                                                                                                           |
| nucleus    | nuclei                     | -us → -i                                                                                                                               |
| cactus     | cacti (or cactuses)        | Both accepted; "cacti" is more formal/scientific                                                                                       |
| syllabus   | syllabi (or syllabuses)    | Both accepted                                                                                                                          |
| alumnus    | alumni                     | Refers to male or mixed-group graduates; "alumna/alumnae" for female                                                                   |
| index      | indices (or indexes)       | "Indices" in mathematics/finance; "indexes" for books                                                                                  |
| appendix   | appendices (or appendixes) | Both accepted; "appendices" more common for books/documents                                                                            |
| medium     | media                      | "The media" is now often treated as singular in modern usage ("the media is powerful"), though traditional grammar treats it as plural |
|            |                            |                                                                                                                                        |

|            |                            |                                                                       |
|------------|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| curriculum | curricula (or curriculums) | Both accepted                                                         |
| formula    | formulae (or formulas)     | "Formulae" more common in mathematics/science                         |
| bacterium  | bacteria                   | "Bacteria" is plural — "these bacteria are," never "this bacteria is" |

**Exam Trap:** "The criteria for selection is unclear." ✗ — "criteria" is plural, so it needs "are": "The criteria for selection are unclear." ✔ This exact error (treating a Latin/Greek plural as singular) is one of the most common CDS-style subject-verb agreement traps.

D. Zero Plural (Same Form for Singular and Plural)

- sheep / sheep
- deer / deer
- fish / fish (usually)
- series / series
- species / species
- aircraft / aircraft
- salmon / salmon
- moose / moose
- offspring / offspring

"I saw one sheep in the field." vs "I saw fifty sheep in the field." (no change — context/number word tells you how many)  
"This aircraft is new." vs "Three aircraft landed today." (never "aircrafts")  
"That species is endangered." vs "Many species are endangered." (never "specieses" or "specie" for singular — "specie" is actually a different word meaning coined money!)

E. Plural-Only Nouns (No Singular Form for "One")

Some nouns referring to items made of two joined/symmetrical parts exist only in plural form. To refer to one, you must use "a pair of."

- scissors
- trousers / pants
- glasses (spectacles)
- pyjamas
- shorts
- tongs
- pliers
- binoculars
- jeans
- tweezers

✗ I need a scissor. → ✔ I need a pair of scissors. / I need scissors.  
✔ These trousers are too long. (always plural verb agreement, even referring to a single item of clothing)  
✔ I bought two pairs of jeans. (to count more than one, count "pairs," not the noun itself)

F. Nouns That LOOK Plural But Are Grammatically Singular

These end in "-s" (looking plural) but name a single subject/field/disease and take a **singular** verb. This is one of the most heavily tested subject-verb agreement traps in competitive English.

"Mathematics is my favourite subject." (not "are")  
"Physics deals with matter and energy." (not "deal")

"Economics affects every part of society." (not "affect")  
 "Athletics is popular in this school." (not "are")  
 "Measles is a highly contagious disease." (not "are")  
 "Mumps usually affects the salivary glands." (not "affect")  
 "Billiards requires great precision." (not "require")  
 "The news is surprising." (already covered above — belongs in this same category)

### G. Nouns That Are Always Plural in Form and Meaning (No True Singular Sense)

"The police are investigating the case." (never "the police is" — "police" always takes a plural verb; to refer to one officer, say "a police officer")  
 "The cattle are grazing in the field." (no singular "a cattle" — use "a cow/bull/head of cattle")  
 "People are gathering outside." (irregular plural of "person"; "peoples," a rarer word, refers to distinct ethnic/national groups: "the diverse peoples of South Asia")

### H. Meaning Shifts Between Singular and Plural Forms

A small but important group of nouns change meaning — sometimes dramatically — when they become plural. These are frequent vocabulary/usage trap questions.

| Singular (Meaning 1)                                                     | Plural (Different Meaning 2)                                                           |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| custom (a habit/tradition) — "It's an old custom."                       | customs (the government border-tax department) — "He was stopped at customs."          |
| arm (body part) — "She broke her arm."                                   | arms (weapons) — "The rebels laid down their arms."                                    |
| manner (a way of doing something) — "He spoke in a calm manner."         | manners (polite social behaviour) — "It's bad manners to interrupt."                   |
| content (subject matter, uncountable) — "The content was interesting."   | contents (the items inside something) — "Check the contents of the box."               |
| letter (an alphabet character, or a written message) — "Write a letter." | letters (literature, scholarship) — "a man of letters"                                 |
| pain (physical suffering, uncountable) — "He was in pain."               | pains (careful effort) — "She took great pains to finish it perfectly."                |
| spirit (soul/attitude) — "team spirit"                                   | spirits (alcohol, or one's mood) — "in high spirits" / "the shop sells spirits"        |
| damage (harm, uncountable) — "The storm caused damage."                  | damages (money awarded in a lawsuit) — "The court awarded damages."                    |
| authority (power, uncountable) — "He has no authority here."             | authorities (officials/organisations in charge) — "The authorities responded quickly." |
| ground (land/surface) — "The ball fell to the ground."                   | grounds (reasons, or an estate) — "He resigned on medical grounds."                    |

### Practice Set 1.6 — Singular/Plural Mastery (35 Questions)

#### Part A: Write the correct plural (1-15)

1. leaf   2. city   3. box   4. potato   5. child   6. mouse   7. photo   8. wife   9. criterion   10. analysis   11. tooth   12. roof   13. day   14. cactus   15. bacterium

**Answers:** 1. leaves   2. cities   3. boxes   4. potatoes   5. children   6. mice   7. photos   8. wives   9. criteria   10. analyses   11. teeth   12. roofs   13. days   14. cacti/cactuses   15. bacteria

#### Part B: Choose the correct verb (singular or plural agreement) (16-25)

16. Mathematics (is/are) a compulsory subject.
17. The police (has/have) arrested the suspect.
18. The criteria for the award (is/are) still being finalised.
19. Physics (deal/deals) with the laws of nature.
20. The scissors (is/are) on the table.
21. Ten sheep (was/were) grazing in the meadow.
22. The news about the merger (was/were) unexpected.
23. His trousers (was/were) torn.
24. The data (suggest/suggests) a clear trend. (traditional usage)
25. Three aircraft (was/were) seen flying in formation.

**Answers:** 16. is 17. have 18. are 19. deals 20. are 21. were 22. was 23. were 24. suggest (traditional; "suggests" increasingly accepted informally) 25. were

### Part C: Meaning-shift plurals — choose the correct word (26–35)

26. He was stopped and questioned at \_\_\_\_\_ (custom/customs) at the airport.
27. It is considered bad \_\_\_\_\_ (manner/manners) to speak with your mouth full.
28. She broke her \_\_\_\_\_ (arm/arms) while climbing.
29. The rebels agreed to surrender their \_\_\_\_\_ (arm/arms).
30. Please check the \_\_\_\_\_ (content/contents) of the parcel before signing.
31. He resigned on medical \_\_\_\_\_ (ground/grounds).
32. She took great \_\_\_\_\_ (pain/pains) to make the event perfect.
33. The court ordered the company to pay \_\_\_\_\_ (damage/damages) to the victims.
34. The storm caused severe \_\_\_\_\_ (damage/damages) to the crops.
35. The local \_\_\_\_\_ (authority/authorities) have announced new traffic rules.

**Answers:** 26. customs 27. manners 28. arm 29. arms 30. contents 31. grounds 32. pains 33. damages 34. damage 35. authorities

## 1.7 Compound Nouns

**Compound noun:** two or more words joined together to function as a single noun with its own distinct meaning.

### Three Forms of Compound Nouns

| Type                                        | Examples                                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Closed</b> (written as one word)         | notebook, football, toothpaste, classroom, headache, sunflower, bedroom, keyboard, girlfriend, homework          |
| <b>Open</b> (written as two separate words) | post office, ice cream, swimming pool, railway station, coffee table, credit card, high school, living room      |
| <b>Hyphenated</b>                           | mother-in-law, six-year-old, well-being, editor-in-chief, commander-in-chief, sister-in-law, runner-up, check-up |

**There is no universal rule for which form a compound takes** — this is largely a matter of convention that changes over time (e.g., "email" was once "e-mail"). When in doubt for writing, check a dictionary; for reading comprehension and grammar exams, focus on recognising them as single semantic units rather than memorising the spelling convention.

### Compound Nouns Can Be Built From Different Word Combinations

noun+noun: toothpaste, football

adjective+noun: blackboard, software

verb+noun: swimming pool, washing machine

noun+verb: sunrise, haircut  
verb+preposition: check-up, drop-out, break-in  
preposition+noun: overcoat, underground

Pluralising Compound Nouns

Usually, add "-s" to the last word (the general rule):

notebook → notebooks | toothbrush → toothbrushes | post office → post offices | swimming pool → swimming pools

EXCEPTION: When the compound has a clear "head noun" that is NOT the last word (often when the compound includes a preposition or "in-law"), pluralise the head noun instead:

mother-in-law → mothers-in-law (NOT "mother-in-laws") | passer-by → passers-by | runner-up → runners-up | commander-in-chief → commanders-in-chief | court-martial → courts-martial | attorney general → attorneys general

When the compound has no clear noun to pluralise (e.g., verb+particle compounds), add "-s" at the end as usual:

check-up → check-ups | drop-out → drop-outs | break-in → break-ins | grown-up → grown-ups

A Note on Stress (Why It Matters)

Compound nouns are usually stressed on the **first** word, while a simple adjective+noun phrase is usually stressed on the **second** word — and the meaning can be completely different:

a **BLACK**bird (stress on "black" — a specific species of bird, compound noun) vs a black **BIRD** (stress on "bird" — any bird that happens to be black in colour, an adjective + noun phrase)  
a **GREEN**house (a structure for growing plants) vs a green **HOUSE** (any house painted green)  
a **DARK**room (a room for developing photographs) vs a dark **ROOM** (any room lacking light)

Practice — Compound Nouns (15 Questions)

Give the correct plural form:  
1. brother-in-law 2. toothbrush 3. runner-up 4. swimming pool 5. editor-in-chief 6. check-up 7. passer-by 8. credit card 9. court-martial 10. drop-out

Identify whether the phrase is a compound noun (single fixed meaning) or an ordinary adjective+noun phrase:  
11. blackboard (writing surface in a classroom) 12. black board (any board painted black) 13. greenhouse (plant-growing structure) 14. white house (any house painted white) 15. hot dog (the food item)

**Answers:** 1. brothers-in-law 2. toothbrushes 3. runners-up 4. swimming pools 5. editors-in-chief 6. check-ups 7. passers-by 8. credit cards 9. courts-martial 10. drop-outs 11. Compound noun 12. Adjective+noun phrase 13. Compound noun 14. Adjective+noun phrase (though "White House," capitalised, is a proper-noun compound referring to the US President's residence!) 15. Compound noun

1.8 Possessive Nouns

**Possessive noun:** a noun form showing ownership, belonging, or a close relationship, usually formed with an apostrophe.

| Case                     | Rule                              | Examples                                             |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Singular noun            | add 's                            | the boy's book, the officer's rifle, India's history |
| Plural noun ending in -s | add only an <b>apostrophe (')</b> | the boys' books, the soldiers' uniforms, the         |

|                                                  |                                                                                                       |                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                  |                                                                                                       | students' results                                                                          |
| Plural noun NOT ending in -s (irregular plurals) | add 's (like a singular noun)                                                                         | the children's toys, the men's room, the women's association, the people's choice          |
| Singular proper noun ending in -s                | add 's (modern convention) — some style guides accept just an apostrophe for classical/biblical names | James's car, the boss's office, Charles's reign; (also seen: Jesus' teachings, Moses' law) |

Joint vs. Individual Possession

**Joint possession** (they own ONE thing together): "Ram and Shyam's house is beautiful." (one shared house — apostrophe only on the last name)

**Individual possession** (they each own a SEPARATE thing): "Ram's and Shyam's houses are both beautiful." (two different houses — apostrophe on each name, and the noun is plural)

Possessive of Compound Nouns

"My mother-in-law's car is new." (apostrophe+s goes at the very end of the whole compound, not after "mother")

"The commander-in-chief's orders were clear."

The "Double Possessive"

English sometimes uses "of" together with an 's-possessive — this is grammatically correct and often used to mean "one of several," especially with indefinite articles:

"He is a friend of mine." (= one of my friends; NOT the same as "he is my friend," which suggests a closer/singular relationship)

"That book of John's is missing." (= one of John's books)

The Most Important Possessive Mistake: "its" vs. "it's"

**This is one of the single most common errors in English, tested constantly:**

**its** = possessive form of "it" (no apostrophe — like "his," "her," possessive pronouns never take an apostrophe)

**it's** = contraction of "it is" or "it has" (the apostrophe here replaces missing letters, NOT showing possession)

✓ **The dog wagged its tail.** (possessive — belongs to the dog)

✗ **The dog wagged it's tail.**

✓ **It's raining outside.** (= "It is raining")

✓ **It's been a long day.** (= "It has been a long day")

✗ **Its been a long day.**

**Quick test:** Try replacing "it's" with "it is" or "it has" in the sentence. If that makes sense, "it's" (with apostrophe) is correct. If not, use "its" (no apostrophe).

Practice — Possessive Nouns (20 Questions)

Write the correct possessive form:

1. the car belonging to the teacher → the \_\_\_\_\_
2. the toys belonging to the children → the \_\_\_\_\_
3. the bags belonging to the students (plural, regular) → the \_\_\_\_\_
4. the room for men → the \_\_\_\_\_
5. the novels of Charles Dickens → \_\_\_\_\_ novels
6. the house that Ravi and Sunita share → \_\_\_\_\_ house
7. the separate offices of the manager and the director → \_\_\_\_\_ offices
8. the toy belonging to the child → the \_\_\_\_\_
9. the decision made by the committee → the \_\_\_\_\_
10. the orders given by the commander-in-chief → the \_\_\_\_\_

Choose "its" or "it's" (11-20):

11. The company announced \_\_\_\_\_ new policy.
12. \_\_\_\_\_ too late to change the plan now.
13. The cat cleaned \_\_\_\_\_ fur.
14. \_\_\_\_\_ been raining since morning.
15. Every rule has \_\_\_\_\_ exception.
16. \_\_\_\_\_ a beautiful day today.
17. The team celebrated \_\_\_\_\_ victory.
18. I think \_\_\_\_\_ going to rain.
19. The government revised \_\_\_\_\_ budget.
20. \_\_\_\_\_ clear that we need more time.

**Answers:** 1. teacher's car 2. children's toys 3. students' bags 4. men's room 5. Charles Dickens's (or Dickens') 6. Ravi and Sunita's 7. the manager's and the director's 8. child's toy 9. committee's decision 10. commander-in-chief's orders 11. its 12. It's 13. its 14. It's 15. its 16. It's 17. its 18. it's 19. its 20. It's

## 1.9 Material Nouns

**Material noun:** names the raw substance or material from which things are made. Usually uncountable.

gold  
silver  
iron  
wood  
cotton  
wool  
leather  
plastic  
glass  
stone  
paper  
cloth  
silk  
steel  
rubber  
clay

"The ring is made of gold." (material)

"Gold prices rose sharply this year." (the substance, as a commodity)

### Shift to Countable: Referring to "Types Of" a Material

Material nouns can become countable when referring to different varieties/types — a subtle but testable shift:



"The silks of Varanasi are famous worldwide." (= different types/varieties of silk)  
"French wines are exported globally." (= different varieties of wine)  
"The museum displayed rare metals." (= different kinds of metal)

Material Noun Used as an Adjective (Attributive Use — Previewed, Fully Covered in 1.12)

a gold ring | a wooden table (note the adjective form "wooden," not "wood table," though "wood table" is sometimes used informally) | a silk saree | an iron gate | a glass jar

1.10 Verbal Nouns and Nominalisation

**Verbal noun (gerund used as a noun):** the "-ing" form of a verb functioning as a noun. **Nominalisation:** the broader process of turning a verb or adjective into a noun form (often using a suffix).

Why This Matters

Nominalisation is everywhere in formal, academic, and news writing — and in comprehension passages, exam questions frequently ask you to recognise the noun form of a verb you already know as a verb. Learning to convert between them fluently is a genuinely high-value skill.

Verbal Nouns (Gerunds as Subjects/Objects)

"Swimming is good exercise." (subject)  
"He enjoys reading." (object)  
"The opening of the ceremony was delayed." (with "the," behaving fully like a noun — can even take "of")

Common Nominalisation Patterns (Verb/Adjective → Noun)

| Suffix        | Examples                                                                                               |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| -tion / -sion | decide→decision, discuss→discussion, act→action, confuse→confusion, permit→permission, decide→decision |
| -ment         | develop→development, govern→government, achieve→achievement, argue→argument, judge→judgement           |
| -ance / -ence | perform→performance, differ→difference, appear→appearance, exist→existence, prefer→preference          |
| -al           | arrive→arrival, refuse→refusal, propose→proposal, approve→approval                                     |
| -ity / -ty    | able→ability, difficult→difficulty, real→reality, equal→equality                                       |
| -ness         | happy→happiness, kind→kindness, dark→darkness (adjective→noun, not verb→noun)                          |

Transformation Practice: Verb Sentence → Nominalised Noun-Phrase Sentence

**Verb form:** "The government decided to increase taxes." →  
**Nominalised:** "The government's decision to increase taxes surprised economists."  
  
**Verb form:** "The team performed well." →  
**Nominalised:** "The team's performance was impressive."  
  
**Verb form:** "Scientists discovered a new species." →  
**Nominalised:** "The discovery of a new species excited scientists."

Practice — Verbal Nouns and Nominalisation (15 Questions)

Convert each verb/adjective to its noun form:

1. decide → \_\_\_\_\_ 2. develop → \_\_\_\_\_ 3. perform → \_\_\_\_\_ 4. arrive → \_\_\_\_\_ 5. able → \_\_\_\_\_ 6. happy → \_\_\_\_\_ 7. discuss → \_\_\_\_\_ 8. govern → \_\_\_\_\_ 9. differ → \_\_\_\_\_ 10. propose → \_\_\_\_\_ 11. exist → \_\_\_\_\_ 12. equal → \_\_\_\_\_ 13. permit → \_\_\_\_\_ 14. achieve → \_\_\_\_\_ 15. refuse → \_\_\_\_\_

**Answers:** 1. decision 2. development 3. performance 4. arrival 5. ability 6. happiness 7. discussion 8. government 9. difference 10. proposal 11. existence 12. equality 13. permission 14. achievement 15. refusal

## 1.11 Noun Phrases

**Noun phrase:** a noun (the "head") together with all the words that modify or complete it, functioning together as a single grammatical unit — wherever you could use a single noun, you can usually use a whole noun phrase instead.

### Building a Noun Phrase Step by Step

**Just the head noun:** books

+ **determiner:** the books

+ **adjective (pre-modifier):** the old books

+ **multiple adjectives:** the old, dusty books

+ **prepositional phrase (post-modifier):** the old, dusty books on the shelf

+ **relative clause (post-modifier):** the old, dusty books on the shelf that no one reads

No matter how long it gets, this whole final phrase — "the old, dusty books on the shelf that no one reads" — behaves as ONE noun phrase. It could be replaced by a single pronoun: "They gather dust." This is the real test of a noun phrase: could the whole chunk be replaced by "it/they/this"?

### The General Structure

[Determiner] + [Pre-modifiers: adjectives/nouns] + **HEAD NOUN** + [Post-modifiers: prepositional phrases / relative clauses / participle phrases]

### Practice — Identify the Head Noun (10 Questions)

Underline/identify the head noun of each noun phrase:

1. the tall soldier standing at the gate
2. a bright red car parked outside
3. the report that was submitted yesterday
4. several important decisions made by the committee
5. the officer's final instructions before departure
6. a large collection of rare coins
7. the students who passed the exam
8. the noise coming from the street
9. an old wooden box full of letters
10. the general's strategy for the campaign

**Answers:** 1. soldier 2. car 3. report 4. decisions 5. instructions 6. collection 7. students 8. noise 9. box 10. strategy

## 1.12 Grammatical Functions of Nouns

A noun (or noun phrase) can play several different roles within a sentence. Recognising which role a noun is playing is essential for sentence analysis, which becomes increasingly important in later chapters (especially error-spotting and comprehension).

| Function | Definition                                   | Example (function in bold)  |
|----------|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Subject  | who/what performs the action or is described | <b>The soldier</b> saluted. |

|                         |                                                                                  |                                                                             |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Direct Object           | who/what directly receives the action                                            | She read <b>the book</b> .                                                  |
| Indirect Object         | who/what receives the direct object (usually "to/for" someone)                   | She gave <b>him</b> the book. (him = indirect object; book = direct object) |
| Subject Complement      | renames/describes the subject (follows a linking verb: be, seem, become, appear) | She is <b>a teacher</b> .                                                   |
| Object Complement       | renames/describes the direct object                                              | They elected him <b>president</b> . (president renames "him")               |
| Object of a Preposition | completes a prepositional phrase                                                 | He sat on <b>the chair</b> .                                                |
| Apposition (Appositive) | a noun phrase placed next to another noun to rename/explain it                   | My friend, <b>a doctor</b> , helped me.                                     |
| Attributive Noun        | a noun used like an adjective, directly modifying another noun                   | a <b>stone</b> wall, a <b>war</b> hero, a <b>coffee</b> cup                 |

Deep Dive: Direct Object vs. Indirect Object

"She gave him the book." → him = indirect object (receiver), the book = direct object (thing given)  
Can be rewritten: "She gave the book to him." (indirect object becomes object of preposition "to")  
"He bought her flowers." = "He bought flowers for her."

Deep Dive: Subject Complement vs. Object Complement

**Subject complement** (follows linking verb, renames SUBJECT): "The exam was **a disaster**." / "He became **an officer**."  
**Object complement** (follows the object, renames the OBJECT): "The team named her **captain**." (captain renames "her," the object) / "We consider him **a hero**." (a hero renames "him")

Deep Dive: Apposition

"Mr. Sharma, our new principal, addressed the students." (the appositive "our new principal" renames "Mr. Sharma")  
"Delhi, the capital of India, is a major hub."  
"My brother Arjun, a software engineer, works in Bangalore."

**Punctuation note:** A non-essential appositive (extra information not needed to identify the noun) is set off with commas, as in all the examples above. An essential appositive (needed to specify which one) is NOT set off with commas: "My brother Arjun works in Bangalore" (no commas, if you have more than one brother and need to specify which one).

Deep Dive: Attributive Nouns (Noun Used as an Adjective)

English frequently uses one noun directly in front of another to modify it, functioning like an adjective — without changing its form:

a stone wall (wall made of stone) | a war hero (hero of war) | a coffee cup (cup for coffee) | a summer holiday | a government official | a security guard | a traffic signal

**Exam Trap:** Attributive nouns are always singular, even when the meaning is plural: **a five-years-old boy** ✗ → **a five-year-old boy** ✓; **a two-hours meeting** ✗ → **a two-hour meeting** ✓. This "singular attributive noun" rule is one of the most common hyphenated-compound errors in competitive exams.

Practice — Identify the Function of the Underlined Noun (15 Questions)

1. The captain led the team. (Subject / Object / Complement)
2. She admired the view. (Subject / Object / Complement)
3. He is a doctor. (Subject / Object / Complement)
4. They gave the winner a trophy. (Direct / Indirect Object)
5. They gave the winner a trophy. (Direct / Indirect Object)
6. We elected her president. (Subject Complement / Object Complement)
7. He lives near the station. (Subject / Object of Preposition)
8. My uncle, a retired colonel, visited us. (Apposition / Subject)
9. She wore a silk saree. (Attributive Noun / Head Noun)
10. He bought a new car. (Attributive Noun / Head Noun)
11. Honesty is the best policy. (Subject / Object)
12. The manager considers him reliable. (this is actually an adjective, not a noun — trick question: can you spot it?)
13. This is a government building. (Attributive Noun / Head Noun)
14. He handed her the keys. (Direct / Indirect Object)
15. Mumbai, India's financial capital, never sleeps. (Apposition / Subject)

**Answers:** 1. Subject 2. Object (direct object) 3. Subject Complement 4. Indirect Object 5. Direct Object 6. Object Complement 7. Object of Preposition 8. Apposition 9. Attributive Noun 10. Head Noun 11. Subject 12. Correct catch — "reliable" is an adjective (object complement), not a noun; this tests whether you're identifying function or just spotting any word after a verb 13. Attributive Noun 14. Direct Object 15. Apposition

### 1.13 Noun Formation: Prefixes and Suffixes (Reference)

Beyond the nominalisation patterns already covered (1.10), these suffixes are worth knowing as a recognition toolkit — especially for vocabulary-in-context and word-formation exam questions.

| Suffix    | Meaning/Use                                             | Examples                                                                                                            |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| -er / -or | agent noun — "one who does X"                           | teach→teacher, act→ <b>actor</b> , direct→ <b>director</b> , drive→driver, write→writer                             |
| -ist      | a person who practises/believes in X                    | science→scientist, art→artist, piano→pianist, terror→terrorist                                                      |
| -ian      | a person associated with a field                        | music→musician, history→historian, politics→politician                                                              |
| -ee       | the RECEIVER of an action (contrast with -er, the doer) | employ→employ <b>ee</b> (vs employ <b>er</b> ), train→train <b>ee</b> (vs train <b>er</b> ), refuge→refuge <b>e</b> |
| -ism      | a belief system, ideology, or practice                  | nation→national <b>ism</b> , capital→capital <b>ism</b> , patriot→patriot <b>ism</b> , terror→terror <b>ism</b>     |
| -age      | an action, state, or result (varied use)                | marry→marri <b>age</b> , store→stor <b>age</b> , short→short <b>age</b>                                             |
| -dom      | a state, condition, or domain                           | free→freed <b>om</b> , king→king <b>dom</b> , bore→bored <b>om</b>                                                  |
| -hood     | a state, period, or group condition                     | child→child <b>hood</b> , brother→brother <b>hood</b> , neighbour→neighbour <b>hood</b>                             |
| -ship     | a state, role, or skill                                 | friend→friend <b>ship</b> , leader→leader <b>ship</b> , relation→relation <b>ship</b> , citizen→citizen <b>ship</b> |

### Common Negative Prefixes (Frequently Attached to Nouns)

| Prefix            | Examples                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| un-               | unemployment, unhappiness, uncertainty                                                                                        |
| dis-              | dishonesty, disagreement, discomfort, disadvantage                                                                            |
| mis-              | misconduct, misunderstanding, mismanagement                                                                                   |
| non-              | nonsense, non-compliance, non-attendance                                                                                      |
| in- / im- / il- / | inability, impatience, illiteracy, irregularity (the prefix form changes to match the sound that follows — a spelling detail) |

|     |                 |
|-----|-----------------|
| ir- | worth noticing) |
|-----|-----------------|

Practice — Word Formation (10 Questions)

Form a noun using an appropriate suffix or prefix:

- 1. employ (the receiver of employment) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 2. employ (the giver of employment) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 3. nation (the ideology) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 4. free (the state) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 5. friend (the state/relationship) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 6. honest (the negative/opposite quality) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 7. agree (the negative/opposite noun) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 8. literate (the negative/opposite noun) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 9. child (the period of life) → \_\_\_\_\_
- 10. lead (the role/position) → \_\_\_\_\_

**Answers:** 1. employee 2. employer 3. nationalism 4. freedom 5. friendship 6. dishonesty 7. disagreement 8. illiteracy 9. childhood 10. leadership

1.14 Gender-Related Noun Distinctions

Traditional English marks gender in a small set of nouns (mostly relating to family roles, titles, and occupations); modern usage increasingly favours common-gender terms for occupations. Both are worth knowing — traditional pairs for reading/exam recognition, and modern preferences for your own writing.

| Masculine  | Feminine                                                                      |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| actor      | actress (though "actor" is now commonly used for all genders in modern usage) |
| prince     | princess                                                                      |
| hero       | heroine                                                                       |
| waiter     | waitress (many now prefer the gender-neutral "server")                        |
| king       | queen                                                                         |
| host       | hostess                                                                       |
| god        | goddess                                                                       |
| lion       | lioness                                                                       |
| emperor    | empress                                                                       |
| bridegroom | bride                                                                         |

Common Gender (No Male/Female Distinction in Form)

- teacher
- doctor
- student
- engineer
- parent
- friend
- cousin
- singer
- writer
- artist

**Modern usage note:** Traditionally gendered occupational titles are increasingly replaced with common-gender forms in formal and professional English: "chairman" → "chairperson/chair," "policeman" → "police officer," "air hostess" → "flight attendant," "fireman" → "firefighter." Competitive exams generally still expect knowledge of the traditional pairs above (for vocabulary/synonym questions), but your own writing should default to the neutral modern form unless referring to a specific historical/traditional context.

## Animal Gender Terms (Occasionally Tested)

bull (male) / cow (female)  
cock/rooster (male) / hen (female)  
stallion (male) / mare (female)  
ram (male) / ewe (female)  
drake (male) / duck (female)  
tiger (male) / tigress (female)

## Practice — Gender Pairs (10 Questions)

Give the corresponding masculine or feminine form:

1. prince → \_\_\_\_\_ 2. lion → \_\_\_\_\_ 3. host → \_\_\_\_\_ 4. hero → \_\_\_\_\_ 5. bull → \_\_\_\_\_ 6. emperor → \_\_\_\_\_ 7. stallion → \_\_\_\_\_  
8. god → \_\_\_\_\_ 9. ram → \_\_\_\_\_ 10. king → \_\_\_\_\_

**Answers:** 1. princess 2. lioness 3. hostess 4. heroine 5. cow 6. empress 7. mare 8. goddess 9. ewe 10. queen

## 1.15 Consolidated Review: High-Value Mistakes Not Yet Covered

The sections above each included their own "common mistakes" box. This section adds a few more noun-related errors that don't belong to any single subtopic, plus brings back the single most important trap from earlier sections for spaced repetition.

### "The number of" vs. "A number of"

"**The** number of" = singular verb (you're talking about the number itself, one figure). "**A** number of" = plural verb (you're using it to mean "several/many," referring to the items).

- ✓ **The number of students is increasing.** (the number, as a figure, is going up — singular)
- ✓ **A number of students are absent today.** (= several students are absent — plural)
- ✗ **The number of students are increasing.**
- ✗ **A number of students is absent today.**

### "Kind of / Sort of / Type of" + Noun Agreement

Singular "kind/sort/type of" pairs with a singular noun; plural "kinds/sorts/types of" pairs with a plural noun. Don't mix them.

- ✓ **This kind of book is popular.**
- ✓ **These kinds of books are popular.**
- ✗ **These kind of books are popular.** (mismatched: plural "these" + singular "kind")
- ✗ **This kinds of book is popular.**

## A Preview: Noun Clauses (Fully Covered in the Clauses Chapter)

An entire clause can function exactly like a noun — as a subject, object, or complement. You met this briefly in Chapter 0 (Example 12: "What he said surprised everyone"). A few more previews:

- "What she decided affected everyone." (noun clause as subject)
- "I don't know where he went." (noun clause as object)
- "The truth is that he lied." (noun clause as subject complement)

We will return to this in full depth later — for now, simply recognise that "noun-like behaviour" isn't limited to single words or phrases; whole clauses can do the same job.

## One More Tricky Countable/Uncountable Word

### brain(s)

Countable, literal (the organ): "The brain controls the nervous system." / "Doctors examined both brains."

Uncountable-feeling idiom (intelligence, informal, always plural in this sense): "She has the brains to solve this problem."  
(NOT "the brain" in this idiomatic sense)

## 1.16 CDS/AFCAT Noun Exam-Trap Cheat Sheet

### Quick-scan list before your exam — each links back to where it was taught in full:

1. Latin/Greek plurals (criteria, phenomena, bacteria) take a **plural** verb, even though they don't end in the familiar "-s." (§1.6C)
2. Words that look plural but are singular subjects (mathematics, physics, news, measles) take a **singular** verb. (§1.6F)
3. Collective nouns (team, jury, government) are usually **singular** in standard/competitive usage unless clearly emphasising disagreement among members. (§1.4)
4. "Few/little" = almost none (negative); "a few/a little" = some, enough (positive). Don't drop the "a" by mistake. (§1.5)
5. "Fewer" for countable nouns, "less" for uncountable nouns — "fewer people," "less time." (§1.5)
6. Uncountable nouns (advice, information, furniture, news) have **no plural form** and never follow "a/an" directly. (§1.5)
7. "Its" (possessive, no apostrophe) vs "it's" (= it is/it has, always has an apostrophe). (§1.8)
8. Attributive nouns before another noun stay **singular**, even with plural meaning: "a five-year-old boy," not "five-years-old." (§1.12)
9. "The number of" = singular verb; "a number of" = plural verb. (§1.15)
10. Plural-only nouns (scissors, trousers, police, cattle) always take a **plural** verb. (§1.6E, 1.6G)

## 1.17 Mixed Practice — Bringing It All Together

These three sets combine everything from Chapter 1 (and revisit Chapter 0 concepts where relevant). Treat this as your chapter-end test, not a teaching tool — attempt each set fully before checking answers.

### Mixed Set 1 — Recognition & Classification (20 Questions)

For each noun, state its category as fully as you can (e.g., "common, countable, concrete"):

1. courage 2. team 3. information 4. Ganga 5. children 6. furniture 7. mathematics 8. scissors 9. sheep (referring to one animal) 10. happiness

Identify the grammatical function of the underlined noun:

11. The general issued new orders.
12. She considers him trustworthy. (careful — is this a noun?)
13. He is my mentor.
14. They gave the team a trophy.
15. My colleague, a brilliant engineer, resigned.
16. This is a leather jacket.
17. She lives near the market.
18. Patience is a virtue.
19. We elected him captain.
20. He bought her a gift.

**Answers:** 1. Abstract, common, uncountable 2. Collective, common, countable (as a unit) 3. Abstract, common, uncountable 4. Proper, concrete, countable (river name) 5. Common, concrete, countable (irregular plural) 6. Common, concrete, uncountable 7. Common, abstract, singular-only (looks plural, grammatically singular) 8. Common, concrete, plural-only 9. Common, concrete, countable (zero-plural noun) 10. Abstract, common, uncountable 11. Subject 12. Not a noun — "trustworthy" is an adjective (object complement) 13. Subject Complement 14. Indirect Object 15. Apposition 16.

## Mixed Set 2 — Application: Fill in the Blank (20 Questions)

1. There isn't \_\_\_\_\_ (much/many) time left.
2. The \_\_\_\_\_ (childs/children) were playing outside.
3. He gave \_\_\_\_\_ (a advice/some advice) about the interview.
4. The jury \_\_\_\_\_ (has/have) reached its verdict.
5. The company revised \_\_\_\_\_ (its/it's) policy.
6. This is my \_\_\_\_\_ (brother-in-law's/brothers-in-law's) house.
7. The \_\_\_\_\_ (criteria/criterion) for selection are strict.
8. He has \_\_\_\_\_ (few/a few) close friends and is quite content.
9. She bought a \_\_\_\_\_ (glass/glasses) of milk.
10. The news \_\_\_\_\_ (is/are) surprising.
11. I need \_\_\_\_\_ (a piece of/a) information about the schedule.
12. The \_\_\_\_\_ (mother-in-laws/mothers-in-law) met for tea.
13. Physics \_\_\_\_\_ (is/are) a challenging subject.
14. He has \_\_\_\_\_ (much/many) friends in the army.
15. This kind of question \_\_\_\_\_ (is/are) common in the exam.
16. \_\_\_\_\_ (The number/A number) of complaints have increased sharply this month.
17. The dog wagged \_\_\_\_\_ (its/it's) tail happily.
18. He bought a \_\_\_\_\_ (wood/wooden) chair.
19. The team \_\_\_\_\_ (is/are) celebrating their victory.
20. There is too \_\_\_\_\_ (much/many) traffic on this road.

**Answers:** 1. much 2. children 3. some advice 4. has 5. its 6. brother-in-law's 7. criteria 8. a few 9. glass 10. is 11. a piece of 12. mothers-in-law 13. is 14. many 15. is 16. A number 17. its 18. wooden 19. is (are also acceptable if emphasising individual celebration, but "is" is the standard exam default) 20. much

## Mixed Set 3 — CDS/AFCAT-Style Error Correction (20 Questions)

Find and correct the noun-related error in each sentence:

1. The criteria for the job is very demanding.
2. She has few good friends, so she never feels alone. (check the logic)
3. The news were released this morning.
4. I need an advice before I decide.
5. Everybody should mind their own business's. (check the apostrophe)
6. There are less people at the meeting than expected.
7. He is a five-years-old boy.
8. The dog hurt it's paw.
9. My brother-in-laws are visiting this weekend.
10. Mathematics are my strongest subject.
11. A number of workers is on strike.
12. These kind of mistakes are common.
13. The company announced it's quarterly results.
14. He gave me many informations about the exam.
15. The committee have (referring to the committee acting as one unit) reached a unanimous decision.
16. Three sheeps were grazing near the fence.
17. This is the boys' (referring to a single boy) bicycle.
18. The team are practising alone in the gym (implying they act as one coordinated unit here).
19. He has two brother-in-law.
20. I don't have much friends here.

**Answers:**

1. "is" → "are" (criteria is plural)
2. "few" → "a few" (logic requires the positive form to match "never feels alone")
3. "were" → "was" (news is singular)



4. "an advice" → "some advice"
5. "business's" → "business" (no apostrophe needed here — "business" isn't possessive in this sentence: "mind their own business")
6. "less people" → "fewer people" (countable)
7. "five-years-old" → "five-year-old" (attributive noun stays singular)
8. "it's" → "its" (possessive)
9. "brother-in-laws" → "brothers-in-law" (pluralise the head noun)
10. "are" → "is" (Mathematics is singular)
11. "is" → "are" ("a number of" takes plural verb)
12. "these kind" → "these kinds" (or "this kind")
13. "it's" → "its" (possessive)
14. "many informations" → "a lot of information"
15. For a unit acting together, "have" → "has" (as stated, the committee acts as one unit here)
16. "sheeps" → "sheep" (zero plural)
17. "boys'" (plural possessive) → "boy's" (singular possessive, since only one boy is meant)
18. If truly acting as one coordinated unit, "are" → "is" (though British usage sometimes allows "are" even here — for CDS purposes, default to "is" for a unit)
19. "two brother-in-law" → "two brothers-in-law"
20. "much friends" → "many friends" (countable)

## 1.18 Mastery Check — Chapter 1: Nouns

Before moving to Chapter 2 (Verbs, in Part B), confirm you can — without hesitation and in unfamiliar sentences — do all of the following:

- Define a noun and identify one in any sentence, including tricky cases where a word could be more than one part of speech.
- Distinguish common/proper, concrete/abstract, and explain why some words shift categories depending on meaning.
- Correctly choose singular or plural verb agreement with collective nouns, mass nouns that look plural (mathematics, news), and Latin/Greek plurals (criteria, phenomena).
- Correctly use much/many, few/a few, little/a little, and fewer/less without hesitation.
- Form correct plurals for regular, irregular, foreign, zero-plural, and plural-only nouns.
- Form correct possessives for singular, plural, irregular-plural, and compound nouns — and never confuse "its" with "it's."
- Correctly pluralise compound nouns, including exceptions like "mothers-in-law."
- Identify the grammatical function of any noun in a sentence: subject, object (direct/indirect), complement (subject/object), apposition, attributive, or object of a preposition.
- Convert common verbs/adjectives into their noun forms (nominalisation) and back.
- Recognise and correct all ten items on the CDS/AFCAT Noun Exam-Trap Cheat Sheet (§1.16) on sight.

If any item feels uncertain, return to that section and redo its practice set before continuing — Chapter 2 assumes full fluency with everything above.

## END OF PART A — WHAT COMES NEXT

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Part A rebuilt two foundational chapters — Sentence Basics and the complete Noun system — at full textbook depth: definitions, dozens of contrastive examples, tricky edge cases, common mistakes, exam traps, and multiple full practice sets with detailed answers, exactly matching the standard you asked for.

**Part B will continue at this same depth with:**

- Chapter 2 — The Complete Verb System (main/auxiliary/modal verbs, transitive/intransitive, finite/non-finite, verb patterns, phrasal verbs)
- Chapter 3 — The Twelve Tenses (each with full structure, timelines, dozens of examples, transformation drills, and mixed-tense practice)
- Chapter 4 — Pronouns, Determiners, and Articles
- Chapter 5 — Adjectives and Adverbs
- ...continuing through the full Level 0–9 syllabus, restructured and expanded exactly as you specified.

Let me know if the depth and style here are right before I continue — or if you'd like anything adjusted (more/fewer examples, different balance of exercises, etc.) before I build Part B at this same scale.